THE HOUSE OF IDEAS

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

“THE ROOFTOP”

May 10 – June 11, 2012
Los Feliz • Cedars-Sinai • Bel Air

An Alternate-History Hollywood Saga

PART ONE: TWO HEARTBEATS

INT. MARC-ANTHONY AND ESTHER'S HOUSE - BEDROOM - LOS FELIZ - NIGHT

SUPER: THURSDAY, MAY 10, 2012 - 12:48 A.M. PDT

Darkness. Two empty bassinets glowing faintly under a nightlight shaped like Mjolnir, a gift from Amond. Esther (29), thirty-six weeks and three days pregnant with twins, sits bolt upright in bed, gripping the sheets.

ESTHER
(through clenched teeth)
Marc.

MARC-ANTHONY (30) is asleep face-down, one arm hanging off the bed. He doesn't move.

ESTHER (CONT'D)
Marc. MARC.

He jolts awake, flailing, and falls completely off the bed with a thud.

MARC-ANTHONY
(from the floor)
I'm up! I'm up! Is it Braxton Hicks?

ESTHER
It's not Braxton Hicks.

MARC-ANTHONY
How do you know?

ESTHER
(gripping the headboard as another wave hits)
Because my water just broke on your grandmother's thousand-thread-count sheets.

Marc-Anthony scrambles to his feet. Fifteen seconds of total, beautiful panic: he grabs the hospital bag, drops it, grabs his phone, puts on one shoe, can't find the other.

ESTHER (CONT'D)
Marc.

MARC-ANTHONY
Yeah?

ESTHER
Breathe. You're Iron Man.

MARC-ANTHONY
(stopping, taking a deep breath)
I'm Iron Man. I'm Iron Man. Iron Man doesn't need a second shoe.

He scoops her up and carries her to the car in one shoe.

CUT TO:

INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S CAR - SUNSET BOULEVARD - CONTINUOUS

SUPER: THURSDAY, MAY 10, 2012 - 1:04 A.M. PDT

Marc-Anthony drives with both hands on the wheel, exactly at the speed limit, sweating. Esther breathes through a contraction in the passenger seat. His phone is on speaker.

DR. PATEL (V.O.)
How far apart?

ESTHER
Five minutes. Maybe four.

DR. PATEL (V.O.)
At thirty-six weeks with twins, that's exactly what we want. I'm already in the car. Cedars, labor and delivery, fourth floor. Marc, stop driving at exactly the speed limit, you're making me nervous.

MARC-ANTHONY
How did you know I'm driving at exactly the speed limit?

DR. PATEL (V.O.)
Because you're you.

Esther laughs through the next contraction, then groans.

ESTHER
Call my mother.

MARC-ANTHONY
Already did. She's getting Simone.

ESTHER
Call your mother.

MARC-ANTHONY
Already did. She's getting the jet.

ESTHER
From BEL AIR?

MARC-ANTHONY
She panicked. I told her it's eleven minutes away by car. She said "I know" and hung up.

CUT TO:

INT. CEDARS-SINAI MEDICAL CENTER - LABOR AND DELIVERY - DELIVERY ROOM - NIGHT

SUPER: THURSDAY, MAY 10, 2012 - 4:05 A.M. PDT

A large delivery room, built for twins: two warmers, two pediatric teams, monitors tracking two heartbeats. Esther, exhausted, sweating, is in the final stage of labor. Marc-Anthony holds her hand, in scrubs and a surgical cap. DR. PATEL (52) is at the end of the bed.

DR. PATEL
Baby A is crowning. Esther, one more big push. Give me everything.

ESTHER
(gasping)
I've been giving you everything for three hours!

DR. PATEL
Then give me everything plus one.

MARC-ANTHONY
(close to her ear)
You lifted a fifteen-pound hammer over your head in front of six thousand people. You can do this.

ESTHER
(through gritted teeth)
That hammer... was... EASIER!

She pushes with everything she has. A beat. Then a cry, thin and furious, fills the room.

DR. PATEL
Baby A! It's a girl! Four twelve a.m.!

A tiny, wet, wailing baby is placed on Esther's chest for a few precious seconds. Marc-Anthony makes a sound that isn't quite a laugh and isn't quite a sob.

ESTHER
(crying, touching the baby's face)
Hi. Hi, Emma. Hi, baby.

MARC-ANTHONY
(barely able to speak)
She looks like you.

ESTHER
She looks like YOU. She's frowning at the lights like they owe her money.

A NURSE gently lifts Emma to the warmer, where the pediatric team swarms her. Then an alarm sounds. A sharp, insistent beeping from Baby B's heart monitor. The room changes in an instant.

NURSE
Doctor, Baby B's heart rate is dropping. Ninety. Eighty-five.

Dr. Patel's face goes completely calm, the professional calm that means something is wrong.

DR. PATEL
Baby B has turned. She's transverse and the cord's compressed. We're going to the OR. Now. Esther, listen to me. We're doing a C-section. She's going to be okay. I need you to trust me.

ESTHER
(terrified)
Marc...

MARC-ANTHONY
(holding her face, his voice steady)
Look at me. She's a Smilley and a Bullock. She's the toughest person in this room. She's going to be fine. I'm right here.

The bed is already moving. Nurses run alongside. Marc-Anthony runs with them, still holding Esther's hand, through the double doors.

CUT TO:

INT. CEDARS-SINAI - FAMILY WAITING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

SUPER: THURSDAY, MAY 10, 2012 - 4:20 A.M. PDT

A private waiting room. Packed. On one side: NATASHA (50) and ROBERT (53), VICTOR (75) and JOAN (74), ELXA (31), GRACE (18). On the other: CELESTE (52), SIMONE (32), CORNELIUS (78), HATTIE (76). In the middle, the people who belong to both: AMOND (30), HARMONY (29), TAYIA (30).

Through the window, they've just seen Esther's bed being rushed toward the OR. Nobody is talking.

Natasha, the most powerful woman in Hollywood, is pacing like a caged animal. Celeste is sitting very still, her hands knotted in her lap.

Natasha stops pacing. She looks at Celeste. Then, slowly, she crosses the room and sits down beside her.

NATASHA
(quietly)
Mrs. Smilley.

CELESTE
(not looking up)
Mrs. Bullock.

A long silence.

NATASHA
I had a C-section with Marc. Thirty years ago, in this hospital. Emergency. They wouldn't tell me anything for forty minutes.

(beat)
Those were the longest forty minutes of my life.

Celeste finally looks at her.

CELESTE
How did you get through it?

NATASHA
My mother held my hand. The whole time. And told me stories about the time she almost fell into the orchestra pit at the Hollywood Bowl.

A beat. Joan, across the room, gives a small, sad smile.

Natasha holds out her hand. Celeste stares at it. Two women whose families have been at war since before either was born.

Celeste takes it.

CELESTE
(a shaky laugh)
I don't have any Hollywood Bowl stories.

NATASHA
Then tell me about Esther when she was little. Anything.

Celeste takes a deep breath.

CELESTE
When she was four, she put on my wedding dress and stood on the dining room table and sang "Amazing Grace" to the cat...

Across the room, Victor and Cornelius both watch their women hold hands. Neither says a word. Hattie rests her head on Cornelius's shoulder. Joan does the same to Victor.

CUT TO:

INT. CEDARS-SINAI - OPERATING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

SUPER: THURSDAY, MAY 10, 2012 - 4:37 A.M. PDT

Bright lights. A blue surgical drape. Esther is awake, numb from the waist down, Marc-Anthony's hand clutched in both of hers. Behind the drape, the surgeons work fast.

DR. PATEL (O.S.)
Almost there. Almost... here she comes.

Silence. A terrible second of silence. Esther's face goes white.

ESTHER
(a whisper)
Why isn't she crying? Marc, why isn't she...

And then: a cry. Loud. Indignant. Absolutely furious at the entire universe. It fills the operating room like thunder.

DR. PATEL (O.S.)
(laughing with relief)
Baby B! Another girl! Four thirty-seven a.m.! And she is NOT happy about any of this!

Esther bursts into sobs. Marc-Anthony presses his forehead against hers.

MARC-ANTHONY
She's okay. She's okay. Listen to her. She's yelling.

A nurse brings the screaming baby around the drape for one second, a tiny red face, fists clenched, mid-roar.

ESTHER
(crying, laughing)
Look at her fight. Look at her. She fought her way out.

(to Marc-Anthony, suddenly certain)
Victoria.

MARC-ANTHONY
Victoria?

ESTHER
It means victory. She fought, Marc. She won.

Marc-Anthony looks at his screaming, furious, perfect second daughter.

MARC-ANTHONY
(softly)
Victoria.

The baby, for one second, stops crying. Then she starts again, twice as loud.

CUT TO:

INT. CEDARS-SINAI - FAMILY WAITING ROOM - DAWN

SUPER: THURSDAY, MAY 10, 2012 - 5:20 A.M. PDT

The door opens. Marc-Anthony walks in, still in scrubs, a surgical cap crooked on his head, his eyes red and his face shining. Every person in the room stands at once.

MARC-ANTHONY
Emma Joan Bullock. Four twelve a.m. Five pounds, six ounces. And Victoria Pearl Bullock. Four thirty-seven a.m. Five pounds, one ounce. They're in the NICU for observation, just a day or two, but they're perfect. Esther's perfect. Everyone's perfect.

The room EXPLODES. Grace screams. Amond bear-hugs Tayia. Harmony bursts into tears. Simone lifts Grace off the ground. Robert grabs his son and holds him.

But two people don't move.

Joan Donohue stands frozen, a hand over her mouth. Emma JOAN.

And Hattie Smilley sits very still, staring at nothing. Victoria PEARL. Named for Hattie's mother-in-law. Pearl Smilley. The woman who paid Joan to leave Cornelius in 1959.

Joan's eyes meet Hattie's across the room. Hattie doesn't know what Joan knows. Joan knows exactly. A whole history passes over Joan's face, and then she smiles.

JOAN
(quietly, to no one)
Emma Joan and Victoria Pearl. Well. That's fitting.

Victor, beside her, catches a different word entirely.

VICTOR
(stunned, to Marc-Anthony)
Victoria?

MARC-ANTHONY
It means victory, Granddad. She fought her way out. Esther named her in the operating room.

Victor turns away for a moment. When he turns back, his eyes are wet.

VICTOR
(very quietly)
Victory. That's a good name.

Cornelius, across the room, has heard all of it. He looks at Victor. Victor looks back. Two great-grandfathers.

CORNELIUS
Desmond is going to think she's named after you.

VICTOR
I know.

CORNELIUS
(a dry smile)
Let him.

CUT TO:

PEOPLE.COM - EXCLUSIVE - FRIDAY, MAY 11, 2012, 9:00 AM ET

MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK AND ESTHER SMILLEY WELCOME TWIN DAUGHTERS!

"Emma Joan and Victoria Pearl arrived on May 10 at Cedars-Sinai. One came the easy way and one came fighting. Both are perfect, and both are already louder than their father." The babies, born at 36 weeks, are healthy and expected to go home within days. The birth comes six days after their parents' film "The Avengers" broke the all-time box office record.

TWITTER.COM - TRENDING TOPICS (WORLDWIDE) - FRIDAY, MAY 11, 2012

#StarkThorTwins - Emma Joan - Victoria Pearl - Welcome Babies - #Avengers

TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE

marcanthonyb: emma joan and victoria pearl. 4:12 am and 4:37 am. i have never been this tired or this happy. their mother is the strongest person alive. thor is a lightweight compared to her. 9:05 AM May 11th from Twitter for iPhone

amondbaker: i'm an uncle. TWICE. i held both of them. victoria yelled at me. emma looked at me like i was disappointing her. they're perfect. i'm crying in the cedars parking lot 9:20 AM May 11th from Twitter for iPhone

tyreseavery: welcome to the world, emma and victoria. your uncle cap will always come get you. 10:02 AM May 11th from web

gammagal: wait. VICTORIA. named after victor donohue?? the smilley-donohue feud baby???? 10:15 AM May 11th from web

NoNerfsPlz: @gammagal people.com says Esther named her in the OR because "she fought her way out." Victoria means victory. Not everything is a feud, Karen 10:18 AM May 11th from Twitter for iPhone

CUT TO:

PART TWO: THE BACK ROW

INT. CEDARS-SINAI - NEONATAL INTENSIVE CARE UNIT - NURSERY WINDOW - DAY

SUPER: SUNDAY, MAY 13, 2012 - 2:00 P.M. PDT - MOTHER'S DAY

A long hallway with a glass window looking into the NICU. Rows of incubators. In two side-by-side bassinets near the window, labeled "BULLOCK, EMMA J." and "BULLOCK, VICTORIA P.," two tiny babies sleep in pink knit caps.

Down the hallway, from the elevators, a man walks slowly. Hat pulled low. Sunglasses indoors. A cream-colored overcoat despite the May heat.

DESMOND SMILLEY (54).

He stops at the very end of the hallway. Twenty feet from the window. He doesn't move closer. He just stands there, looking through the glass at two pink caps.

He stays there for five minutes. Perfectly still.

A door opens behind him. Marc-Anthony walks out of the NICU parents' room in scrubs, carrying a cup of hospital coffee. He sees Desmond. Stops.

Desmond sees him too. Neither moves.

MARC-ANTHONY
(very quietly)
Mr. Smilley.

DESMOND
(not looking at him, eyes on the glass)
Which one is which?

Marc-Anthony walks slowly to the window. He stands beside Desmond. Not too close. Not too far.

MARC-ANTHONY
The one on the left is Emma. She came first. Four twelve. She's the calm one. She stares at everything like she's grading it.

(beat)
The one on the right is Victoria. Four thirty-seven. Her cord got compressed. They had to do an emergency C-section. For about four seconds in the operating room, she didn't cry, and I've never been so scared in my life.

(beat)
Then she started screaming and hasn't really stopped since.

Desmond's jaw tightens. His eyes are fixed on the baby on the right.

DESMOND
(cold, quiet)
Victoria.

MARC-ANTHONY
Yes, sir.

DESMOND
You named my granddaughter after your grandfather.

A long pause. Marc-Anthony doesn't flinch.

MARC-ANTHONY
No, sir. Your daughter named her. In the operating room. Right after she started screaming. Esther said, "Look at her fight. She fought her way out. Victoria. It means victory."

(beat)
Her middle name is Pearl. After your grandmother. That was Esther's idea too.

Desmond goes completely still. Behind his sunglasses, something cracks.

DESMOND
(barely audible)
...Pearl.

MARC-ANTHONY
Esther said your grandmother Pearl was the toughest woman who ever lived. That she managed the family's money on the Chitlin' Circuit while Zeke danced. She said Victoria would need that.

Desmond takes off his sunglasses. His eyes are red. He's been crying in the elevator, or in the car, or for days.

DESMOND
Is my daughter all right?

MARC-ANTHONY
She's tired. She's sore. She's the strongest person I've ever met. And she's in Room 412 with her mother right now, because it's Mother's Day. Simone's there. Your father's there.

(beat)
She'd want to see you, sir. I know she would.

DESMOND
(shaking his head)
I can't walk in there. Not after December. Not after the column. I said things...

MARC-ANTHONY
You sat in her seat at the Magic Johnson. Back row. Seven-ten. You texted her.

(beat)
That text is the only thing she's talked about for a week. She read it to me eleven times.

A long silence. Desmond looks through the glass at the two babies.

A NICU NURSE (40s) pushes open the door, holding a clipboard.

NICU NURSE
Mr. Bullock? Victoria's due for her feeding. Would you like to come do it?

Marc-Anthony looks at the nurse. Then at Desmond. A beat. Then he turns back to the nurse.

MARC-ANTHONY
Actually, would it be all right if her grandfather did it? He's family. I'll vouch for him.

Desmond turns sharply to look at him. The nurse looks between the two men, sensing the weight of the moment without understanding it.

NICU NURSE
Of course. He'll just need to scrub in and put on a gown.

DESMOND
(hoarse)
I... I don't...

MARC-ANTHONY
(quietly)
You don't have to say anything to me, Mr. Smilley. Not today. Maybe not ever. Just go feed your granddaughter.

CUT TO:

INT. CEDARS-SINAI - NICU - CONTINUOUS

SUPER: SUNDAY, MAY 13, 2012 - 2:20 P.M. PDT

A quiet corner of the NICU. A rocking chair. Soft beeping monitors. DESMOND SMILLEY, in a yellow paper gown over his expensive suit, sits in the rocking chair, holding a tiny pink bundle as if it were made of glass. The nurse adjusts his arms and hands him a two-ounce bottle.

NICU NURSE
Tilt it a little. Let her set the pace. There you go.

Victoria latches onto the bottle and starts drinking furiously. Desmond lets out a short, startled laugh.

DESMOND
She's... she's very determined.

NICU NURSE
That one? She's the loudest baby on the floor. The night nurses call her "the Thunderer."

Desmond looks down at the baby in his arms. Tiny. Furious. Brown eyes blinking up at him. And for the first time in years, everything else falls away: the feud, the Oath, the Donohues, 1966, PREMIERE magazine, all of it.

DESMOND
(whispering to the baby)
Hello, Victoria. I'm your grandfather.

(beat)
I made a lot of mistakes. Your mother will tell you about them someday. Probably all of them.

(his voice breaking)
But I'm going to try very hard not to make any more with you.

Victoria stops drinking, looks up at him, and lets out a single tiny, imperious squawk. Then she goes back to the bottle.

Desmond laughs through his tears.

DESMOND (CONT'D)
You're right. That was too much to promise.

Behind him, the NICU door opens quietly. Esther stands there in a hospital gown and robe, leaning on Simone's arm, pale and exhausted. She's been wheeled down by a nurse for her own feeding session. She sees her father in the rocking chair, in a paper gown, holding her daughter.

Esther doesn't say anything. She can't.

Desmond looks up. Sees her. For a long moment, father and daughter look at each other across the quiet NICU.

DESMOND (CONT'D)
(very softly)
Happy Mother's Day, baby girl.

Esther's face crumples. Simone helps her across the room. Esther sinks down onto the arm of the rocking chair, and her father, still holding Victoria, puts his free arm around her for the first time in five months.

They sit like that, the three of them, while the monitors beep softly.

In the doorway, Simone wipes her eyes. Behind her, in the hallway, Marc-Anthony watches through the glass. He doesn't come in. He just smiles, turns, and goes to find Emma.

CUT TO:

TMZ.COM - MONDAY, MAY 14, 2012

DESMOND SMILLEY SPOTTED AT CEDARS NICU ON MOTHER'S DAY - FEUD OVER?

A hospital source says the Smilley patriarch stayed three hours, fed one of the twins, and "cried the whole time." When asked for comment outside the hospital, Smilley said only: "She's very determined." Then he got into his car.

BOX OFFICE MOJO - MONDAY, MAY 14, 2012

'THE AVENGERS' SECOND WEEKEND: $107.4 MILLION - BIGGEST SECOND WEEKEND OF ALL TIME

The film reaches $1.03 billion worldwide on its 19th day of global release, tying the record for the fastest film ever to cross $1 billion.

CUT TO:

PART THREE: THE LETTER

EXT. DONOHUE ESTATE - FRONT DRIVE - BEL AIR - NIGHT

SUPER: WEDNESDAY, MAY 30, 2012 - 7:00 P.M. PDT - VICTOR DONOHUE'S 76TH BIRTHDAY

A warm evening. The great house glows behind the gates. A vintage Lincoln Town Car pulls up the long drive. A BUTLER opens the door.

CORNELIUS SMILLEY (78) steps out, in his best suit, leaning on his cane. HATTIE (76) follows in a lavender dress.

On the front steps stand VICTOR DONOHUE (76 today) and JOAN (74). Behind them, discreetly, an elderly man in a three-piece suit, holding a leather briefcase: LELAND BROOKS (82), the family attorney.

Cornelius looks up at the house. It's the first time he's ever seen it.

CORNELIUS
So this is what forty-six years of being right looks like.

VICTOR
(quietly)
No, Neil. This is what forty-six years of being alone looks like. It just has better landscaping.

CUT TO:

INT. DONOHUE ESTATE - VICTOR'S STUDY - NIGHT

SUPER: WEDNESDAY, MAY 30, 2012 - 9:15 P.M. PDT

After dinner. Dark wood, leather, a fire in the fireplace despite the warm night. On the mantel, a framed photograph that Cornelius notices immediately: two young men on a Harlem rooftop in 1958, arms around each other's shoulders, laughing. The same photo that has been in Cornelius's breast pocket for half a century.

Cornelius stares at it.

CORNELIUS
You kept it.

VICTOR
On my desk, Neil. Every day. For fifty-four years.

Cornelius slowly reaches into his own breast pocket and pulls out the identical photograph, worn soft and creased from decades of handling. He holds it up next to the frame. The two copies of the same moment, side by side.

Hattie and Joan, seated on a leather couch, watch in silence.

Victor nods to Leland Brooks. The old lawyer opens his briefcase and takes out a yellowed envelope, sealed with old wax, addressed in fountain pen: "Neil."

LELAND BROOKS
Mr. Smilley. I've had this in a safe-deposit box at the Bank of America on Wilshire since January 3, 1967. Mrs. Donohue and I are the only two people alive who have ever touched it. It's yours.

He holds it out. Cornelius takes it with trembling hands. He looks at Victor.

CORNELIUS
What is this?

VICTOR
The truth. I wrote it on New Year's Eve, 1966. Two weeks after my father died. I was going to give it to you the week after New Year's. And then you filed suit against me, and called me a thief in JET magazine, and I...

(beat, his voice breaking)
I was a proud, stupid young man, Neil. And then I was a proud, stupid old man. Read it. Please.

Cornelius sits down heavily in a leather armchair by the fire. He breaks the wax seal. Six pages of fountain-pen handwriting, yellowed. He puts on his reading glasses and begins to read.

The room is silent except for the crackle of the fire.

We hear fragments of the letter in VICTOR'S VOICE as Cornelius reads:

VICTOR (V.O.)
(younger, 30 years old, urgent)
"Neil. The bank came to me on the night of the funeral. Harrison Whitcomb. He said the FBI has a file on you. Montgomery, the boycott money, the people you know from the theater. He said the lenders will call every loan unless the company cuts every tie with you. The Florida project dies. Three thousand jobs. My father's whole life..."

Cornelius's hand begins to shake.

VICTOR (V.O.) (CONT'D)
"...so I am doing the worst thing I have ever done. I am signing the papers. I am buying you out at the bank's number, which is a lie, and the Fund goes with it. But tonight I have also created a trust, in your name and your children's names, holding Donohue stock equal to what you are truly owed, every penny of the Fund and your share of everything we built. I named it the Rooftop Trust. It's yours. It always was. I'll give it to you the moment the bank is satisfied..."

Cornelius takes off his glasses. He presses a hand over his eyes. His shoulders are shaking.

VICTOR (V.O.) (CONT'D)
"...You are the best friend I ever had. I'm sorry it took a bank to show me what I'm willing to lose. Happy New Year, Neil. Forgive me if you can.
- V."

Cornelius lowers the letter. For a long time, he can't speak. Hattie crosses the room and kneels beside his chair, holding his arm. Finally:

CORNELIUS
(hoarse)
The FBI.

VICTOR
They followed you home from the theater. For years. You knew that.

CORNELIUS
I knew they followed me. I didn't know they followed me into your company.

(beat, anger rising)
You let me hate you, Victor. For forty-five years. You let my father die swearing an Oath against your name. You let my son grow up believing you were a thief.

VICTOR
Yes.

CORNELIUS
(standing, his voice rising, filling the room)
WHY?

VICTOR
(quietly, not defending himself)
Because when you called me a thief in JET, it hurt so much that I decided I'd rather be hated than forgiven. Forgiveness would have meant admitting I needed you.

(beat)
That's the whole reason, Neil. There's no better one.

Cornelius stares at him. The anger in his face burns, flickers, and slowly, slowly, starts to go out.

CORNELIUS
And the trust?

Leland Brooks clears his throat and opens a second folder.

LELAND BROOKS
The Rooftop Trust, sir. Irrevocable. Established December 30, 1966. It holds Donohue Entertainment Class A shares, currently valued at approximately seven point two billion dollars. Upon Mr. Donohue's death, it vests in equal shares among all of your living direct descendants.

Hattie gasps. Cornelius sways slightly on his cane.

CORNELIUS
Seven... billion...

LELAND BROOKS
Yes, sir. Your children. Your grandchildren.

(beat, glancing at Victor)
And, as of May 10th of this year, your great-grandchildren.

A long silence. Cornelius slowly turns to look at Victor.

CORNELIUS
Emma and Victoria.

VICTOR
Are beneficiaries of the trust I made for you in 1966. Yes.

(a strange, broken laugh)
Our great-granddaughters, Neil. My blood and yours. Inheriting the money I took from you. Fifty years later. If that isn't God laughing at both of us, I don't know what is.

Cornelius looks at the letter in his hand. At the two photographs on the mantel. At his old friend, seventy-six years old today, standing alone by the fire, waiting to be forgiven or condemned.

And then Cornelius Smilley does something he hasn't done since 1966. He laughs. A real laugh. A deep, rolling, Central Park laugh that fills the study.

CORNELIUS
God's been laughing at us since the day we met, Victor. In the chorus of BELLS ARE RINGING. You stepped on my foot in the first number.

VICTOR
(laughing too, tears running down his face)
You stepped on mine first.

CORNELIUS
I did NOT.

VICTOR
You did. Opening night. I still have the bruise.

The two old men laugh until they're crying. Hattie and Joan look at each other across the room. Joan reaches over and takes Hattie's hand.

Then Cornelius puts down his cane, steps forward, and puts his arms around his oldest friend. For the first time since 1966. Victor holds on like a drowning man.

CORNELIUS
(into his shoulder)
Happy birthday, you proud old fool.

VICTOR
(barely audible)
Happy New Year, Neil. Forty-five years late.

CUT TO:

INT. DONOHUE ESTATE - VICTOR'S STUDY - LATER

SUPER: WEDNESDAY, MAY 30, 2012 - 11:40 P.M. PDT

The fire is low. Two old men in leather armchairs, a bottle of 1966 scotch between them (Victor saved it), two glasses. Hattie and Joan have gone to the terrace. Leland Brooks has gone home.

CORNELIUS
Desmond.

VICTOR
I know.

CORNELIUS
My son has built his entire life on hating your family. Every choice he's ever made. His marriage. His children's careers. The Oath. If I tell him the truth...

VICTOR
It will destroy him.

CORNELIUS
Or it will set him free.

A long silence.

VICTOR
Ten days ago he sat in a NICU in a paper gown and fed my great-granddaughter a bottle. Natasha told me. He cried for three hours.

CORNELIUS
I was there. I watched through the glass.

VICTOR
Then maybe he's already starting to be free, Neil. Maybe he doesn't need the truth yet. Maybe he needs those babies first.

Cornelius thinks about it for a long time.

CORNELIUS
And Joan? There's something she's not telling either of us. I saw her face in the hospital when Marc-Anthony said "Victoria Pearl." She looked like she'd seen a ghost.

Victor looks toward the terrace door, where Joan stands in the moonlight with Hattie.

VICTOR
(quietly)
I've been married to her for fifty-two years, Neil. She has one secret from me. I've always known it was there. I've never asked.

CORNELIUS
Maybe it's time somebody did.

VICTOR
Not tonight. Tonight I got my best friend back.

(raising his glass)
To the rooftop.

CORNELIUS
(raising his)
To the rooftop.

They drink. On the terrace, outside the glass doors, Joan looks back into the study at the two old men laughing by the fire. Her face is happy, and haunted, at the same time.

FADE OUT.

HEADLINES

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER - THURSDAY, MAY 31, 2012

SPOTTED: CORNELIUS SMILLEY ARRIVES AT VICTOR DONOHUE'S 76TH BIRTHDAY IN BEL AIR

The first visit to the Donohue estate by any member of the Smilley family in recorded Hollywood history. Witnesses report the two patriarchs stayed in Victor's study until nearly 1 a.m. The sound of laughter could be heard from the driveway.

DEADLINE.COM - THURSDAY, MAY 31, 2012

IS THE GREATEST FEUD IN HOLLYWOOD HISTORY OVER?

Six weeks ago: "Hello, Neil." Two weeks ago: Desmond Smilley in a NICU. Last night: Cornelius Smilley at Victor Donohue's birthday. Both families declined to comment. One insider: "Two babies did in three weeks what lawyers couldn't do in forty-five years."

JET MAGAZINE - COVER (Issue of June 11, 2012)

EMMA & VICTORIA: THE BABIES WHO ENDED A WAR

First photos inside. Plus: Why a 1966 bottle of scotch was opened in Bel Air last week.

BOX OFFICE MOJO - SUNDAY, JUNE 3, 2012

'THE AVENGERS' PASSES $1.3 BILLION WORLDWIDE; BECOMES THIRD-BIGGEST FILM OF ALL TIME

FADE OUT.

END OF CHAPTER FIFTEEN